

SKILLED WORKER VISA



LOCATION: [HOME](#) » [WORK & BUSINESS IMMIGRATION](#) » [LONG TERM WORK VISAS](#) » [UK SKILLED WORKER VISA](#)

UK Skilled Worker Visa: UK Work Visa Route for Sponsored Employment

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In This Guide

1. Requirements for a UK Skilled Worker Visa
2. Skilled Worker Visa UK: Certificate of Sponsorship (CoS) Explained
3. Job Skill Level Criteria for the UK Skilled Worker Visa
4. UK Skilled Worker Visa: English Language Test & Exemptions
5. Minimum Salary & Going Rate for UK Skilled Worker Visa Jobs
6. UK Immigration Salary List: Impact on Skilled Worker Visa Eligibility
7. Skilled Worker Visa for New Entrants: Lower Salary Thresholds
8. Financial Maintenance Requirement for the UK Skilled Worker Visa
9. When Is a Criminal Record Certificate Needed for the Skilled Worker Visa?
10. Skilled Worker Visa: Is the Resident Labour Market Test Still Required?
11. UK Skilled Worker Visa: Cooling-Off Period Rules Explained
12. Bringing Family to the UK on a Skilled Worker Visa: Dependant Rules
13. Switch to the UK Skilled Worker Visa from Another Immigration Route
14. How to Apply for a UK Skilled Worker Visa: Step-by-Step Guide

- [15. UK Skilled Worker Visa Costs: Fees & Health Surcharge](#)
- [16. Fast-Track Options for UK Skilled Worker Visa Applications](#)
- [17. How Long Does a UK Skilled Worker Visa Last?](#)
- [18. Maximum Stay on a UK Skilled Worker Visa: Is There a Time Limit?](#)
- [19. How to Change Jobs on a UK Skilled Worker Visa](#)
- [20. Redundancy on a Skilled Worker Visa: What Are Your Options?](#)
- [21. Can You Work a Second Job on a Skilled Worker Visa?](#)
- [22. Is Self-Employment Allowed on a UK Skilled Worker Visa?](#)
- [23. Reporting Job or Personal Changes on a Skilled Worker Visa](#)
- [24. Skilled Worker Visa Sponsor Duties & Visa Compliance Requirements](#)
- [25. Indefinite Leave to Remain on a Skilled Worker Visa: ILR Requirements](#)
- [26. Switching from Skilled Worker Visa to Another UK Immigration Route](#)
- [27. Reasons UK Skilled Worker Visa Applications Are Refused](#)
- [28. What to Do If Your Skilled Worker Visa Is Refused: Appeal & Review](#)
- [29. UK Skilled Worker Visa Pros and Cons: Opportunities & Limitations](#)
- [30. UK Skilled Worker Visa FAQs](#)
- [31. How Our Immigration Barristers Can Help](#)
- [32. Contact Richmond Chambers Immigration Barristers](#)

The Skilled Worker Visa allows individuals of any nationality to live and work in the UK, provided they have an offer of employment in an eligible skilled role from a UK employer that is approved and licensed by the Home Office to sponsor workers. The role must meet minimum salary and skill level requirements, and the applicant must satisfy criteria including English language proficiency. The visa can lead to indefinite leave to remain after five years of continuous residence and employment in the UK. Applicants can also be joined or accompanied by dependent partners and children, who may live, work and study in the UK.

In order to secure a Skilled Worker Visa you will need to be sponsored to do a specific job, which meets certain skill and salary requirements, by an employer that has been licensed by the Home Office. We have published separate guidance for UK employers considering applying for a [Skilled Worker sponsor licence](#).

If you are interested in setting up a new business in the UK, or you own an existing UK business, you may be eligible for a Skilled Worker visa via self-sponsorship, that is by being sponsored by your own UK company. For full details, please see our dedicated [Self-Sponsorship Skilled Worker Visa](#) page.

If you are a doctor, nurse, paramedic, adult social care worker, or other eligible healthcare professional, you may qualify for the Health and Care subcategory of the Skilled Worker Visa. This route offers reduced fees, exemption from the Immigration Health Surcharge, and expedited processing, provided the role is with an approved sponsor in the health or care sector and is listed as an eligible occupation. For full details, please see our dedicated [Health and Care Worker Visa](#) page.

There is no cap on the number of people who can enter the UK on the Skilled Worker route.

1. Requirements for a UK Skilled Worker Visa

To qualify for a UK Skilled Worker Visa, you must meet specific requirements set out by UK Visas and Immigration. These include criteria relating to your age, job offer, salary level, English language skills, and more.

You will need to show that:

- You are aged 18 or over at the time of application.
- You have a valid [Certificate of Sponsorship \(CoS\)](#) issued by a UK employer licensed to sponsor Skilled Worker migrants.
- Your job offer is for a genuine vacancy that meets the criteria for sponsorship under the Skilled Worker route.
- The role is at the required skill level, typically RQF Level 6 (degree level equivalent) or above.
- You will be paid a salary that meets the minimum salary requirements, which includes both a general salary threshold and the 'going rate' for your occupation, according to the SOC 2020 codes.
- Your sponsor has paid the [Immigration Skills Charge](#), if this is required for your role.

- You meet the English language requirement, usually by demonstrating competence at CEFR Level B1 (equivalent to IELTS 4.0-5.0 in reading, writing, speaking, and listening).
- You have enough money to support yourself on arrival in the UK, unless your sponsor confirms that they will cover your maintenance.
- You have provided a criminal record certificate, if the job you are applying for is in a sector that requires one (such as education, health, or social care).
- You have provided a valid tuberculosis **(TB) test certificate**, if you are applying from a country where TB screening is required.

Meeting the Skilled Worker Visa Requirements

The exact Skilled Worker Visa requirements that apply to you will depend on your individual circumstances, the nature of the job you have been offered, and whether any exemptions or tradeable points apply.

For example, lower salary thresholds may apply if you are under 26, a recent graduate, working in an occupation on the Immigration Salary List, or have a relevant PhD.

It is important to ensure that your application is prepared carefully and that all evidence is submitted correctly. Seeking expert advice from a qualified immigration lawyer can help you avoid delays or refusals.

To discuss your Skilled Worker Visa or **Skilled Worker Sponsor Licence** application with one of our immigration barristers, contact our Skilled Worker Route lawyers on 0203 617 9173 or complete our enquiry form below.

2. Skilled Worker Visa UK: Certificate of Sponsorship (CoS) Explained

To apply for a Skilled Worker Visa, you must have a valid **Certificate of Sponsorship (CoS)** for the specific job you intend to do in the UK. Your CoS must be issued by an employer that is licensed by the Home Office to sponsor workers under the Skilled Worker route.

If your organisation is not yet licensed, you can find out more about how to apply for a **Skilled Worker Sponsor Licence** or browse our **Skilled Worker Sponsor**

Licence success stories.

Sponsor Requirements

Your sponsor must be listed as A-rated on the Home Office's [Register of Licensed Sponsors](#), unless you were last granted permission as a Skilled Worker and are applying to continue working for the same sponsor as in your most recent permission.

CoS Validity and Mandatory Information

Your Certificate of Sponsorship must have been issued no more than 3 months before the date of your Skilled Worker Visa application.

Your Certificate of Sponsorship must also include certain mandatory information, including:

- Your full name, job title, and salary;
- A start date that is no later than 3 months after the date of your Skilled Worker visa application;
- Confirmation that the CoS has not been withdrawn by your sponsor.

Proving a Genuine Job Offer for a UK Skilled Worker Visa

In order to be granted a Skilled Worker Visa, you must show that you are being sponsored to undertake a genuine vacancy, and that you are capable of performing the role for which the Certificate of Sponsorship has been assigned.

If the Home Office has reasonable grounds to believe that the job does not genuinely exist, the job is a sham or the role has been created primarily to facilitate your visa application then your application will be refused.

The Home Office will also want to be satisfied that you have not entered into an arrangement whereby you will fill a temporary or permanent position, or undertake contract work which involves undertaking an ongoing routine role or providing an ongoing routine service to a third party who is not your sponsor. Such arrangements may result in refusal if they contravene the rules governing sponsored employment.

Immigration Skills Charge for UK Skilled Worker Sponsors

Your sponsor must pay any applicable [Immigration Skills Charge \(ISC\)](#) in full when assigning your Certificate of Sponsorship, with the amount depending on the size of the sponsoring organisation and the length of employment being sponsored.

However, there are several key exemptions. Employers are not required to pay the charge when sponsoring workers in certain research or academic roles, including chemical scientists, biological scientists, biochemists, physical scientists, social scientists, R&D managers, and higher education teaching professionals, among others. The charge is also waived for workers who were assigned a certificate before 6 April 2017, as well as for any dependents of the main applicant. Sponsors are further exempt where a student switches into a Skilled Worker visa and later extends their stay.

3. Job Skill Level Criteria for the UK Skilled Worker Visa

To qualify for a Skilled Worker Visa, the job you are being sponsored for must meet the minimum skill level requirement set by UK Visas and Immigration.

Under the Skilled Worker route, the role must be skilled to at least RQF Level 6, which is broadly equivalent to degree level. This does not mean that you must personally hold a degree or any specific formal qualification. Instead, it is the skill level of the job itself – as defined by the Home Office – that determines eligibility.

Eligible Occupations and SOC 2020 Codes

The Home Office sets out eligible jobs in [Appendix Skilled Occupations](#), [Appendix Immigration Salary List](#) and [Appendix Temporary Shortage List](#) of the Immigration Rules.

Each eligible role is assigned a SOC 2020 occupation code, and your sponsor must select a code that accurately reflects the job you will be doing. You must be sponsored for a job that appears in one of the above appendices.

Choosing the Correct Occupation Code

It is the responsibility of your sponsor to select the most appropriate occupation code for the role. If the Home Office has reasonable grounds to believe that your sponsor has selected an inappropriate code, your Skilled Worker Visa application will be refused.

When assessing this, the Home Office will consider factors such as whether your sponsor has demonstrated a genuine need for the job as described, whether you possess the relevant skills, qualifications, and experience to perform the role and your sponsor's track record of compliance with immigration requirements.

Choosing an incorrect or inflated occupation code is a common reason for refusal, so it is important that both the job description and your background match the selected role.

4. UK Skilled Worker Visa: English Language Test & Exemptions

To qualify for a Skilled Worker Visa, you must demonstrate English language ability at level B1 (intermediate level) or above on the Common European Framework of Reference for Languages (CEFR). This must be demonstrated across all four components: reading, writing, speaking and listening.

How to Meet the Skilled Worker English Language Requirement

You can satisfy the English language requirement for a Skilled Worker Visa in any of the following ways:

- You are a national of a majority English-speaking country, as defined by the Home Office.
- You have passed a Secure English Language Test (SELT) in speaking, listening, reading, and writing, at CEFR Level B1 or higher, with an approved test provider.
- You have been awarded a degree or higher qualification that was taught in English and is equivalent to a UK bachelor's degree or above. If the qualification was awarded outside the UK, it must be confirmed by Ecctis (formerly UK NARIC) as meeting the requirement.
- You obtained a GCSE, international GCSE, A level, Scottish National Qualification at level 4 or 5, or Scottish Higher or Advanced Higher, in English, which was awarded by an approved qualification body while you were at school in the UK and you were under 18.
- You have previously met the B1 English language requirement in a successful application for entry clearance or permission to stay in the UK.

Each of these routes is subject to specific evidential requirements, so it is important to ensure the correct documentation is provided as part of your application.

5. Minimum Salary & Going Rate for UK Skilled Worker Visa Jobs

To sponsor a worker under the Skilled Worker Visa route, UK employers must (subject to any applicable tradable points) pay a salary that meets or exceeds both:

- The general salary threshold, and

- The 'going rate' for the relevant job, as defined by the SOC 2020 occupation code in Appendix Skilled Occupations.

The salary you receive as a Skilled Worker will therefore usually need to equal or exceed the following:

- The general salary threshold – for most jobs this is £41,700 per year, but may be £37,500 or £33,400 per year if the worker scores 'tradable points' (see below). The exceptions to the above are as follows:
 - For workers previously granted permission as a Skilled Worker before 4 April 2024 and applying before 4 April 2030, the general salary threshold is £31,300, but may be £28,200 or £25,000 if the worker scores 'tradable points' (see below);
 - For workers sponsored for a Health and Care ASHE salary job, the general salary threshold is £31,300, but may be £28,200 or £25,000 if the worker scores 'tradable points' (see below);
 - For workers sponsored in a Health or Education SOC 2020 occupation code where going rates are based on national pay scales, the general salary threshold is £25,000 (see below); and
- The applicable 'going rate' for the SOC 2020 occupation code in [Appendix Skilled Occupations](#) – or a percentage of the 'going rate' if the worker scores 'tradable points' (see below).

Going Rate Requirement

Each occupation code has a 'going rate' specified in Appendix Skilled Occupations. If the going rate is higher than the general threshold, you must be paid at least the going rate. If the general threshold is higher, you must be paid at least the general threshold.

The going rate is based on a 37.5-hour week and must be pro-rated to match the weekly working hours stated on the Certificate of Sponsorship (CoS).

General Salary Threshold: Calculating Hours

The general salary threshold is based on gross earnings for a maximum of 48 hours per week. If your work pattern varies, hours over 48 per week can be considered, provided the average over a fixed cycle (no longer than 17 weeks) does not exceed 48 hours per week. Unpaid rest weeks must be included in the average.

Tradable Points System for Skilled Worker Visa: Lower Salary Options

Some sponsored skilled workers applying under the Skilled Worker route may be paid less than £41,700 per year, where they are awarded additional so-called 'tradable points' for other attributes:

- An applicant with a PhD qualification which is relevant to the job may be paid a salary which equals or exceeds both £37,500 per year and 90% of the going rate for the SOC 2020 occupation code;
- An applicant with a PhD qualification in a STEM subject which is relevant to the job may be paid a salary which equals or exceeds both £33,400 per year and 80% of the going rate for the SOC 2020 occupation code;
- An applicant with a job offer for a job on the [Immigration Salary List](#) may be paid a salary which equals or exceeds both £33,400 per year and the going rate for the SOC 2020 occupation code;
- An applicant who is a new entrant to the labour market at the start of their career may be paid a salary which equals or exceeds both £33,400 per year and 70% of the going rate for the SOC 2020 occupation code.

Skilled Worker Salary Rules for Visas Granted Before April 2024

Applicants who were granted permission as a Skilled Worker under the rules in place before 4 April 2024, have held permission as a Skilled Worker continuously since and apply for further leave before 4 April 2030 may be paid a salary which equals or exceeds the following:

- The general salary threshold – for most jobs this is £31,300 per year, but may be £28,200 or £25,000 per year if the worker scores 'tradable points' (see below); and
- The applicable 'going rate' for the SOC 2020 occupation code in Appendix Skilled Occupations – or a percentage of the 'going rate' if the worker scores 'tradable points' (see below).

Some Skilled Workers who were granted permission as a Skilled Worker under the rules in place before 4 April 2024 may be paid less than £31,300 per year, where they are awarded additional so-called 'tradable points' for other attributes:

- An applicant with a PhD qualification which is relevant to the job may be paid a salary which equals or exceeds both £28,200 per year and 90% of the going rate for the SOC 2020 occupation code;

- An applicant with a PhD qualification in a STEM subject which is relevant to the job may be paid a salary which equals or exceeds both £25,000 per year and 80% of the going rate for the SOC 2020 occupation code;
- An applicant with a job offer for a job on the [Immigration Salary List](#) may be paid a salary which equals or exceeds both £25,000 per year and the going rate for the SOC 2020 occupation code;
- An applicant who is a new entrant to the labour market at the start of their career may be paid a salary which equals or exceeds both £25,000 per year and 70% of the going rate for the SOC 2020 occupation code.

Salary Thresholds for Health and Care Skilled Worker Visa Applicants

Applicants who are being sponsored for a Health and Care Annual Survey of Hours and Earnings (ASHE) job may be paid a salary which equals or exceeds the following:

- The general salary threshold – for most jobs this is £31,300 per year, but may be £28,200 or £25,000 per year if the worker scores ‘tradable points’ (see below); and
- The applicable ‘going rate’ for the SOC 2020 occupation code in Appendix Skilled Occupations – or a percentage of the ‘going rate’ if the worker scores ‘tradable points’ (see below).

Some sponsored Health and Care Workers applying for a Health and Care Annual Survey of Hours and Earnings (ASHE) job may be paid less than £31,300 per year, where they are awarded additional so-called ‘tradable points’ for other attributes:

- An applicant with a PhD qualification which is relevant to the job may be paid a salary which equals or exceeds both £28,200 per year and 90% of the going rate for the SOC 2020 occupation code;
- An applicant with a PhD qualification in a STEM subject which is relevant to the job may be paid a salary which equals or exceeds both £25,000 per year and 80% of the going rate for the SOC 2020 occupation code;
- An applicant with a job offer for a job on the [Immigration Salary List](#) may be paid a salary which equals or exceeds both £25,000 per year and the going rate for the SOC 2020 occupation code;
- An applicant who is a new entrant to the labour market at the start of their career may be paid a salary which equals or exceeds both £25,000 per year

and 70% of the going rate for the SOC 2020 occupation code.

Pay Scales for NHS & Education Jobs under the Skilled Worker Visa

Applicants who are being sponsored for a job in an eligible health and education SOC 2020 occupation code where going rates are based on national pay scales may be paid a salary which equals or exceeds the following:

- The general salary threshold -£25,000 per year; and
- The applicable 'going rate' for the SOC 2020 occupation code in Appendix Skilled Occupations.

UK Skilled Worker Visa: Hourly Pay Requirements Explained

For most SOC 2020 occupation codes, you will also need to be paid a minimum hourly rate of £17.13 per hour. This hourly rate requirement will apply even if you are eligible for a discount on the going rate based on tradable points and £17.13 is more than 70%, 80% or 90% of the stated going rate.

If you were previously granted permission as a Skilled Worker before 4 April 2024 and are applying before 4 April 2030 or you are a worker being sponsored for a Health and Care ASHE salary job then you will need to be paid a minimum hourly rate of £12.82 per hour. This hourly rate requirement will apply even if you are eligible for a discount on the going rate based on tradable points and £12.82 is more than 70%, 80% or 90% of the stated going rate.

If you are being sponsored in a Health or Education SOC 2020 occupation code where going rates are based on national pay scales, then you will not need to satisfy an hourly rate requirement.

6. UK Immigration Salary List: Impact on Skilled Worker Visa Eligibility

The **Immigration Salary List (ISL)** is maintained by the Home Office and identifies specific skilled occupations where there is a recognised shortage of workers within the UK labour market. These roles are considered difficult to fill with resident workers, and as a result, they benefit from lower salary thresholds under the Skilled Worker route. With the introduction of the **Temporary Shortage List**, the Immigration Salary List is being phased out with removal dates added to the SOC codes.

Skilled Worker Visa Salary Discounts for ISL Occupations

If the job you are being sponsored for is listed on the Immigration Salary List, your sponsor may be permitted to offer a lower salary than the standard general salary threshold, provided all other eligibility requirements are met and the application is made before the date of removal from the ISL.

- For most Skilled Worker occupations on the ISL, you may be paid a salary that is at least £33,400 per year and meets or exceeds the going rate for the relevant SOC 2020 occupation code.
- For Health and Care Worker Visa occupations (excluding those with salaries based on national pay scales) that are on the ISL, the minimum salary may be reduced to £25,000 per year, provided the salary also meets or exceeds the going rate for the role.

These reduced salary thresholds are part of the tradable points system, which allows applicants to trade lower salaries for other attributes, such as working in a job on the Immigration Salary List.

7. Skilled Worker Visa for New Entrants: Lower Salary Thresholds

The UK Skilled Worker route provides a lower salary threshold for applicants who qualify as new entrants to the labour market. This is intended to assist younger workers and early-career professionals in accessing skilled work opportunities in the UK.

Who Qualifies as a New Entrant?

You may be classified as a new entrant if, at the time of application, one of the following applies:

- You are under the age of 26;
- You are switching from a Student visa or Graduate visa;
- You are being sponsored in a postdoctoral research position listed in Table 1 or Table 2 of Appendix Skilled Occupations;
- You are working towards a recognised UK professional qualification, full registration, or chartered status in a regulated profession.

If you qualify as a new entrant, your salary may be set at £33,400 per year (or £25,000 under transitional rules or in eligible health and care jobs), provided this also meets at least 70% of the going rate for the relevant SOC 2020 occupation code.

Time Limit on New Entrant Status

You will not be eligible for new entrant status if the grant of your application would result in your combined permission under either the Skilled Worker, Tier 2 (General) or Graduate categories exceeding 4 years.

This 4-year cap includes the duration of any previously granted visas under these categories, including time spent in any Tier 2 route, Graduate route or as a Skilled Worker.

8. Financial Maintenance Requirement for the UK Skilled Worker Visa

In most cases, you will need to demonstrate that you can financially support yourself when you arrive in the UK. This is known as the financial requirement or maintenance requirement.

Standard Requirement

Unless exempt, you must show that you have at least £1,270 in available cash funds.

The funds must have been held for a minimum of 28 consecutive days ending not more than 31 days before the date of your Skilled Worker Visa application.

Exemptions from the Financial Requirement

You will be exempt from the financial requirement if you are sponsored by a fully 'A-rated' sponsor who certifies on your Certificate of Sponsorship (CoS) that they will cover your maintenance costs up to £1,270 during your first month of employment in the UK (known as the maintenance certification).

If you are applying for permission to stay (i.e., an in-country application), and you have been lawfully resident in the UK for 12 months or more at the date of application you will meet the financial requirement and will not need to show funds.

9. When Is a Criminal Record Certificate Needed for the Skilled Worker Visa?

If you are applying for entry clearance (a visa application from outside the UK) and are being sponsored for certain jobs involving vulnerable people – typically in the health, care, welfare, or education sectors – you may be required to provide a criminal record certificate.

When Is a Criminal Record Certificate Required?

You must provide a criminal record certificate unless it is not reasonably practicable to do so, if:

- You are being sponsored for an occupation listed in Appendix Skilled Occupations as requiring a criminal record check; and
- Since the age of 18, you have lived in any country for a total of 12 months or more (whether continuously or cumulatively) in the 10 years before the date of your application.

This requirement applies per country – you will need to provide a certificate from each country meeting the above condition.

10. Skilled Worker Visa: Is the Resident Labour Market Test Still Required?

Unlike its predecessor route, there is no requirement for employers sponsoring skilled workers under the Skilled Worker Visa route to undertake a Resident Labour Market Test (RLMT). However, sponsors must still be seeking to fill a genuine vacancy.

Unlike the former Tier 2 (General) Visa, the Skilled Worker Visa route does not require employers to carry out a Resident Labour Market Test (RLMT) before sponsoring a migrant worker.

However, while the formal RLMT has been abolished, sponsors must still be able to demonstrate that the job is genuine. The Home Office may refuse an application if there are reasonable grounds to believe that the job does not exist, the vacancy is a sham, or the role has been created primarily to enable a visa application.

Sponsors must therefore ensure that the role is a real vacancy, aligned with their business needs, and that the occupation code used is appropriate for the job being offered.

11. UK Skilled Worker Visa: Cooling-Off Period Rules Explained

Under the previous Tier 2 (General) Visa route, applicants for entry clearance or permission to switch into the route were generally subject to a 12-month 'cooling-off period'. This meant they could not apply if they had been in the UK as

a Tier 2 (General) migrant in the preceding 12 months, unless certain exceptions applied.

No Cooling-Off Period Under the Skilled Worker Route

The cooling-off period has been abolished under the Skilled Worker Visa route. There is no restriction on when you can apply to enter or re-enter the Skilled Worker route, regardless of any previous leave under Tier 2 or Skilled Worker categories.

This provides greater flexibility for Skilled Worker applicants and their sponsors, especially in cases of contract renewal, role changes, or return to the UK after a short break abroad.

12. Bringing Family to the UK on a Skilled Worker Visa: Dependant Rules

As a Skilled Worker, you may be accompanied or joined in the UK by your dependant family members, subject to eligibility and evidential requirements. Workers sponsored in occupations on either the Immigration Salary List or [Temporary Shortage List](#) at RQF levels 3-5 are not able to bring dependants unless the worker is already on the Skilled Worker route in an occupation at RQF levels 3-5 and able to bring dependants as a result of legal provisions in place before the changes.

Who Qualifies as a Dependent?

The following family members can apply as your dependants:

- Your spouse or civil partner;
- Your unmarried partner, provided you have been in a relationship akin to marriage for at least 2 years at the time of application;
- Your child under the age of 18, including if they were born in the UK during your stay;
- Your child is aged 18 or over, only if they are already in the UK as your dependent and are applying to extend their stay.

Each dependent must meet separate financial requirements, and you will need to show evidence of your relationship and, in the case of children, demonstrate that they are not leading an independent life.

13. Switch to the UK Skilled Worker Visa from Another Immigration Route

If you currently hold leave to remain in the UK under another immigration category, you may be able to switch into the Skilled Worker route, provided you meet the eligibility requirements and are not in a restricted category.

Who Cannot Switch into the Skilled Worker Route?

You cannot switch into the Skilled Worker route if you currently have, or were last granted, permission as a Visitor, Short-term student, Parent of a Child Student, Seasonal Worker, Domestic Worker in a Private Household or a person granted leave outside the Immigration Rules.

There are also limitations on switching to being sponsored as a Care Worker for a transitional period until it is removed on 22 July 2028. You will need to have been working for the sponsor for at least 3 months prior to the CoS being issued.

Switching from the Student Route

If you currently have, or were last granted, leave as a Student, you may switch into the Skilled Worker route only if one of the following applies:

- You have completed the course of study for which your Confirmation of Acceptance for Studies (CAS) was assigned; or
- The course has ended before the start date of your sponsored employment, as stated on your Certificate of Sponsorship (CoS); or
- The course was a PhD programme, and you have completed at least 24 months of study.

You must also meet all other Skilled Worker visa requirements, including sponsorship, salary, skill level, and English language ability.

14. How to Apply for a UK Skilled Worker Visa: Step-by-Step Guide

Applying for a Skilled Worker Visa is a multi-stage process, and each step must be followed carefully to avoid unnecessary delays or the risk of refusal.

The first stage is to secure a genuine job offer from a UK employer that holds a **Skilled Worker sponsor licence**. Once the employer has agreed to sponsor you, they must assign you a **Certificate of Sponsorship (CoS)**. This is an electronic document that includes a unique reference number which you will need for your

visa application. The CoS must be issued no more than three months before the date you submit your application.

Once you have your Certificate of Sponsorship, you will need to gather the necessary supporting documents. These typically include a valid passport or travel document, proof that you meet the English language requirement (unless an exemption applies), evidence that you meet the financial maintenance requirement (again, unless exempt), a tuberculosis (TB) test certificate if required for your country of residence, and a criminal record certificate if your job involves working in sectors such as health, care, or education.

You will then need to complete the online Skilled Worker Visa application form through the Home Office website. As part of the application process, you will be asked to upload your supporting documents, pay the relevant application fee, and pay the [Immigration Health Surcharge](#).

After submitting your application, most applicants will need to provide biometric information. If you are applying from outside the UK, this typically involves attending a visa application centre (VAC). If you are applying from within the UK, you will usually attend a UKVCAS service point. In some cases, particularly for in-country applications, you may be able to submit your identity information digitally using the UK Immigration: ID Check app without needing to attend an appointment in person.

Once your biometrics have been provided, your Skilled Worker Visa application will be processed. Standard processing times are usually around three weeks for applications made outside the UK, and up to eight weeks for applications made from within the UK. In some locations, you may be able to pay for a faster priority or super priority service.

If your application is approved, you will be granted permission to enter or remain in the UK as a Skilled Worker. You will typically receive an eVisa, confirming your immigration status digitally.

15. UK Skilled Worker Visa Costs: Fees & Health Surcharge

Applicants for a Skilled Worker Visa must pay an application fee and, in most cases, an Immigration Health Surcharge. The application fee varies depending on whether the visa is for up to three years or for more than three years, and whether the role is listed on the Immigration Salary List.

As of April 2025, the standard fee is £719 for a Skilled Worker Visa up to three years when applying from outside the UK, or £885 when applying from inside the UK. For a Skilled Worker Visa longer than three years, the fee is £1,519 when applying from outside the UK, or £1,751 when applying from inside the UK. Applicants for jobs on the Immigration Salary List benefit from reduced fees.

In addition to the application fee, most Skilled Worker Visa applicants must pay the **Immigration Health Surcharge (IHS)**. The IHS provides access to the UK's National Health Service and is charged at £1,035 per year, payable upfront for the full duration of the visa. For example, a three-year visa would usually incur an IHS cost of £3,105. Applicants sponsored for a Health and Care Worker role are exempt from paying the IHS.

Both the visa application fee and the Immigration Health Surcharge must be paid when submitting the online application. In limited circumstances, partial or full refunds may be available, for example if an application is withdrawn early or refused before biometrics are enrolled. However, applicants should note that Skilled Worker Visa fees are generally non-refundable once the application has been considered on its merits.

16. Fast-Track Options for UK Skilled Worker Visa Applications

Applicants who require a faster decision on their Skilled Worker Visa application may be eligible to use a premium service. The **Priority Service** typically results in a decision within five working days of providing biometrics, while the **Super Priority Service** offers a decision within one working day. These services are available for both applications made from outside the UK and certain applications made within the UK, subject to availability.

The Priority Service carries an additional fee of £500, while the Super Priority Service costs £1,000 on top of the standard visa application fee. Availability can vary depending on the visa application centre or UKVCAS centre, and services may be suspended during periods of high demand. It is important to note that purchasing a faster service does not guarantee a successful outcome. If the Home Office needs to request further information or documents, processing may take longer than the advertised timeframe.

Applicants considering a priority service should check whether it is available at the time of application and ensure that their documentation is complete to avoid unnecessary delays.

17. How Long Does a UK Skilled Worker Visa Last?

If your application for a Skilled Worker Visa is approved, you will be granted entry clearance or permission to stay for a period ending 14 days after the end date stated on your Certificate of Sponsorship (CoS).

The end date on your CoS must reflect the length of your sponsored employment and may be for a period of up to five years from the start date specified. The visa granted will therefore usually cover the period of your sponsored employment, plus an additional 14 days.

A Skilled Worker may be granted leave for up to 5 years at a time, depending on the details of the sponsorship.

Time spent in the UK under the Skilled Worker route can count towards settlement (indefinite leave to remain), which is typically available after five continuous years of qualifying residence.

18. Maximum Stay on a UK Skilled Worker Visa: Is There a Time Limit?

Under the former Tier 2 (General) visa route, applicants were subject to a maximum stay of six years in the route, after which they were generally required to leave the UK or switch to another immigration category.

This restriction has been removed under the Skilled Worker route. There is now no time limit on how long a person can remain in the UK as a Skilled Worker, provided they continue to meet the relevant visa requirements and extend their permission accordingly.

While there is no cap on the total duration of stay, Skilled Workers may become eligible to apply for indefinite leave to remain (settlement) after five years of continuous lawful residence in the UK, subject to meeting all other requirements for settlement.

19. How to Change Jobs on a UK Skilled Worker Visa

If you hold a Skilled Worker Visa and wish to change employer, you must apply for a new Skilled Worker visa before starting work with your new sponsor. Your new employer must be licensed to sponsor workers under the Skilled Worker route and must assign you a new Certificate of Sponsorship (CoS) for the role. The job must meet all the usual eligibility criteria, including minimum salary and skill level requirements.

You must not begin working for your new employer until your new Skilled Worker application has been approved by the Home Office. However, you may continue working for your current sponsor during the application process, provided your existing leave remains valid.

A new application is also required if you change occupation codes or, in some instances, move into a role that falls under a different salary threshold, even if you are remaining with the same employer. This includes situations where the nature of the job changes significantly such that it falls under a different Standard Occupational Classification (SOC) 2020 code.

If you submit a new Skilled Worker application before your existing visa expires and continue to comply with the conditions of your current leave, your continuous residence in the UK for the purposes of settlement (indefinite leave to remain) will not be broken.

20. Redundancy on a Skilled Worker Visa: What Are Your Options?

If your employment ends due to **redundancy** while you are in the UK on a Skilled Worker Visa, your sponsor is legally required to report the termination of your employment to the Home Office within 10 working days.

Following this notification, the Home Office will normally take steps to curtail your visa, giving you a 60-day grace period (or until the original visa expiry date, if sooner). During this period, you must either:

- Find a new licensed sponsor and apply for a new Skilled Worker visa;
- Apply to switch into another immigration route for which you are eligible; or
- Make arrangements to leave the UK.

If you are able to secure a new job offer from a UK employer licensed to sponsor Skilled Workers, you must submit a new Skilled Worker Visa application before the end of the 60-day period. You cannot begin working for your new employer until the Home Office has approved your new visa.

If you are unable to find a new sponsor within this time, you may wish to explore alternative visa routes. If no suitable route is available, you must leave the UK before your leave expires in order to avoid overstaying.

It is essential to remain fully compliant with UK immigration rules during this transitional period, as any breach – such as overstaying – could negatively impact your ability to obtain a UK visa in the future.

21. Can You Work a Second Job on a Skilled Worker Visa?

Skilled Worker visa holders are permitted to undertake additional paid work, referred to as **supplementary employment**, provided specific conditions are met.

Supplementary work must:

- Be in a role listed in Table 1, Table 2, or Table 3 of Appendix Skilled Occupations;
- Not exceed 20 hours per week; and
- Be performed outside the working hours stated on the Certificate of Sponsorship (CoS) for the sponsored job.

If these conditions are met, you do not need to inform the Home Office or amend your visa before taking on the supplementary role.

However, if you wish to take on additional work that does not meet these conditions, for example, if it is more than 20 hours per week or in an occupation not listed in Appendix Skilled Occupations – you will need to apply for secondary employment. This requires:

- A second Certificate of Sponsorship from the new employer;
- A new Skilled Worker visa application, confirming that you wish to vary your existing permission to include the second job; and
- You must already be working for your primary sponsor before applying for secondary employment.

You must not begin the second job until you have received Home Office approval.

Skilled Worker visa holders may also undertake voluntary work, provided it meets the definition of volunteering or voluntary work under the Immigration Rules and does not interfere with the sponsored job.

Working in breach of your visa conditions, for example, through unauthorised employment, self-employment, or excessive working hours can lead to visa cancellation, refusal of future applications, or enforcement action.

22. Is Self-Employment Allowed on a UK Skilled Worker Visa?



Skilled Worker Visa holders are generally prohibited from being self-employed. You must work for your sponsoring employer under the terms stated in your Certificate of Sponsorship and must be paid through PAYE. You cannot operate your own business, work as a freelance contractor, or invoice third parties directly for your services.

An exception to this general prohibition may apply where an individual has established a UK company that has obtained a Skilled Worker sponsor licence and sponsors themselves through a **self-sponsorship** arrangement. However, strict requirements apply to ensure genuine employment and compliance with sponsor duties.

Before engaging in any form of business activity or freelance work, Skilled Worker Visa holders should seek professional advice to ensure they remain compliant with their immigration conditions.

23. Reporting Job or Personal Changes on a Skilled Worker Visa

Skilled Worker Visa holders must ensure that any significant changes to their employment or personal circumstances are properly managed to remain compliant with their immigration conditions. Some changes must be reported by your sponsor to the Home Office, while others may require you to submit a new visa application.

If your new role falls under a different occupation code, you will need to obtain a new Certificate of Sponsorship and apply for a new Skilled Worker Visa before starting the new role.

Other changes, such as reduction of salary, or changes to normal work location not listed on your Certificate of Sponsorship, may also need to be reported. Some changes, particularly where the nature of your role or salary is significantly altered, can affect your eligibility for continued sponsorship.

Changes to your personal circumstances, such as a change of address or a change of name, should also be updated on your UKVI account if you have an eVisa.

Failure to correctly manage changes in circumstances can lead to visa curtailment or future immigration applications being refused. It is always advisable to seek legal advice if you are unsure whether a change requires action.

24. Skilled Worker Visa Sponsor Duties & Visa Compliance Requirements

Both Skilled Worker Visa holders and their sponsoring employers must comply with specific immigration rules and **sponsorship duties**. The ability of a Skilled Worker to remain in the UK depends not only on their own compliance but also on the ongoing compliance of their sponsor.

Sponsors are required to monitor their sponsored workers and report certain changes to the Home Office. This includes reporting if a sponsored worker does not turn up for work, is absent from work without permission for more than 10 consecutive working days, or if their employment ends earlier than stated on the Certificate of Sponsorship. Sponsors must also keep **accurate records** of their sponsored workers' contact details, immigration status documents, and employment terms.

For Skilled Worker Visa holders, it is crucial to ensure that they continue to work in the role for which they were sponsored, maintain the agreed salary and working hours, and comply with the conditions of their stay. Engaging in unauthorised work, failing to update personal information, or breaching visa conditions can lead to visa curtailment, refusal of future applications, and adverse immigration consequences.

If a sponsor loses their sponsor licence or becomes downgraded to a B-rating, this can also impact a Skilled Worker's immigration status. Skilled Workers should remain aware of their sponsor's status and seek prompt advice if they are notified of any changes.

Given the complexity of sponsor compliance obligations, both employers and sponsored workers are encouraged to seek professional advice to mitigate the risk of inadvertent breaches.

25. Indefinite Leave to Remain on a Skilled Worker Visa: ILR Requirements

To qualify for **settlement (indefinite leave to remain) as a Skilled Worker**, you must satisfy UK Visas and Immigration that you meet the following criteria:

- You must have spent a continuous period of five years in the UK. This period can be made up of time spent with permission on any of the following immigration routes (or a combination of them): Skilled Worker, Global Talent, Innovator Founder, T2 Minister of Religion, International Sportsperson, Representative of an Overseas Business, Tier 1 Migrant (excluding Tier 1 (Graduate Entrepreneur)), or the Scale-up route.

- During each 12-month period of the qualifying five years, you must not have been absent from the UK for more than 180 days. These absences are assessed on a rolling basis.
- You must have passed the Life in the UK Test, unless you are aged 65 or over.
- Your sponsor must continue to be a Home Office-approved sponsor at the time of your application.
- Your sponsor must confirm that they still require you to work for them for the foreseeable future and that you will be paid at least the minimum salary (see below) for the foreseeable future.
- You must be paid at least the minimum salary required for settlement, which is the higher of:
 - the general salary threshold applicable at the time (currently £41,700 per year for most applicants), or
 - the going rate for your SOC 2020 occupation code, as specified for settlement purposes.

If any transitional salary thresholds apply (e.g. for those who were sponsored before 4 April 2024), these should be taken into account in line with the latest Immigration Rules.

26. Switching from Skilled Worker Visa to Another UK Immigration Route

While the Skilled Worker Visa provides a clear path to settlement in the UK, some visa holders may later decide to switch to a different immigration route that better suits their long-term career or personal goals. Transitioning to another route is possible in many cases, provided the eligibility requirements are met.

Popular alternative immigration routes include the [Global Talent Visa](#) for individuals who are leaders or potential leaders in their fields, the [Innovator Founder Visa](#) for those wishing to establish and run an innovative business in the UK, and the [Scale-up Visa](#) for those employed in fast-growing UK companies. Each of these routes offers different advantages, such as greater flexibility in employment, self-employment opportunities, or accelerated routes to settlement.

To transition to another immigration route, an applicant must submit a new visa application before their current permission expires. In some cases, such as switching into the Global Talent route, individuals may be able to apply from within the UK, while other categories may require an application from overseas.

Switching routes can have implications for continuous residence requirements for settlement, so it is important to carefully consider the timing and legal strategy before making any change. Seeking expert immigration advice can help ensure a smooth transition and protect long-term immigration objectives.

27. Reasons UK Skilled Worker Visa Applications Are Refused

Although the Skilled Worker Visa route is designed to be accessible, applications are sometimes refused due to common mistakes or omissions. One frequent ground for refusal is failure to meet the minimum salary or skill level requirements for the role. Inaccurate salary calculations, particularly where bonuses or irregular payments are incorrectly included, can lead to rejection.

Another common issue is the selection of an inappropriate Standard Occupational Classification (SOC) code. The Home Office will refuse applications where it considers that the wrong code has been chosen to artificially meet the salary or skill thresholds.

Genuine vacancy concerns may also arise where the Home Office suspects that the role does not genuinely exist or has been created primarily to support a visa application. Failure to provide adequate evidence of English language ability, or an incomplete financial maintenance declaration, can also lead to refusal.

Errors in the Certificate of Sponsorship, such as mismatched job start dates or missing mandatory information, frequently cause applications to be refused. To minimise the risk of refusal, it is important to ensure that any Skilled Worker Visa application is carefully prepared and supported by clear, consistent documentation.

28. What to Do If Your Skilled Worker Visa Is Refused: Appeal & Review

If your Skilled Worker Visa application is refused, you may have the right to request an **Administrative Review** of the decision. Administrative review is available where you believe that a caseworking error was made when assessing your application. The request must be submitted within 14 days if you are in the UK, or 28 days if you are outside the UK.

Following an Administrative Review request, a different Home Office official will reconsider your application. New evidence is generally not permitted unless it is directly relevant to proving a caseworking error.

You may also consider making a fresh Skilled Worker Visa application. A new application can address the reasons for the initial refusal and provide additional or corrected evidence as needed.

Appeal rights to the immigration tribunal are generally not available in Skilled Worker Visa cases unless, very exceptionally, the refusal raises human rights grounds. Skilled Workers facing a refusal should seek prompt legal advice to explore the best strategy based on their circumstances.

29. UK Skilled Worker Visa Pros and Cons: Opportunities & Limitations

The Skilled Worker Visa offers a number of important advantages for those seeking to build a career in the UK. It provides a clear route to settlement after five years, the ability to bring dependant family members, and a wide range of eligible occupations across multiple industries. The removal of the Resident Labour Market Test and the cooling-off period compared to previous routes also makes the process more straightforward for applicants and sponsors alike.

However, the Skilled Worker route does have challenges. Visa holders are tied to their sponsoring employer and role, meaning that career changes require careful immigration planning. Strict salary thresholds and occupational codes can limit flexibility, particularly in industries where pay structures vary or roles evolve rapidly. Dependence on the sponsor's ongoing compliance with immigration requirements adds another layer of vulnerability.

However, for those who plan carefully, maintain compliance, and choose sponsors with a strong track record, the Skilled Worker Visa can be an excellent pathway to achieving long-term personal and professional goals in the UK.

30. UK Skilled Worker Visa FAQs

Who is eligible to apply for a UK Skilled Worker Visa?



What is a Certificate of Sponsorship and why is it important?



What are the minimum salary requirements for a Skilled Worker Visa?



How long does it take to process a Skilled Worker Visa application?



Can I bring my family to the UK on a Skilled Worker Visa?



Can I change jobs or employers on a Skilled Worker Visa?



What costs are involved in applying for a Skilled Worker Visa?



What are common reasons for Skilled Worker Visa refusals?



Can I apply for settlement after holding a Skilled Worker Visa?



Is self-employment allowed on a Skilled Worker Visa?



31. How Our Immigration Barristers Can Help

Applying for a UK Skilled Worker Visa can be procedurally complex and highly regulated, with strict requirements for sponsorship, eligibility, salary thresholds, and compliance. At Richmond Chambers, our immigration barristers provide expert legal guidance to both skilled workers and sponsoring employers throughout every stage of the visa process.

Advice for Skilled Worker Visa Applicants

We work closely with individual clients seeking to live and work in the UK under the Skilled Worker route. Our barristers can:

- Assess your eligibility under the Skilled Worker Visa requirements, including tradable points and minimum salary thresholds;
- Advise on the correct SOC code and ensure your [Certificate of Sponsorship](#) is accurate and compliant;
- Assist in preparing a complete visa application with robust supporting evidence;
- Respond to Home Office queries and address common pitfalls that may lead to refusal;
- Advise on switching immigration categories, bringing dependants, and progressing to settlement in the UK.

Our approach is meticulous, personalised, and focused on achieving a positive outcome while minimising the risk of delay or refusal.

Skilled Worker Sponsor Licence Support

We also advise UK employers who wish to sponsor migrant workers under the Skilled Worker route. Our business immigration barristers provide strategic assistance with:

- Preparing and submitting [Skilled Worker Sponsor Licence applications](#);
- Advising on the suitability of roles and salary levels under [Appendix Skilled Occupations](#);
- Drafting compliant sponsor documentation and a compelling business case;
- Managing the Certificate of Sponsorship process for new hires;
- Ensuring sponsor duties are understood and implemented across your HR systems.

Ongoing Compliance and Sponsor Risk Management

Maintaining your sponsor licence requires continuous compliance with evolving Home Office regulations. We help employers to:

- Understand and discharge sponsor duties, including monitoring and reporting obligations;
- Conduct internal [immigration audits](#) and resolve issues before a Home Office visit;
- Prepare for compliance visits or respond to adverse Home Office decisions, including downgrades or [suspensions](#);
- Mitigate risks associated with job changes, [redundancy](#), or changes in migrant circumstances.

Whether you are an individual planning your move to the UK or an employer looking to expand your international workforce, our immigration barristers provide clear, strategic and practical advice throughout the Skilled Worker visa journey.

32. Contact Richmond Chambers Immigration Barristers

At Richmond Chambers, we pride ourselves on being approachable, responsive, and proactive in understanding and meeting our clients' needs. We are a highly

driven team, committed to delivering clear and reliable immigration advice as part of a professional and friendly service.

To speak with one of our immigration barristers about your Skilled Worker Visa application, Skilled Worker Sponsor Licence application or Skilled Worker Compliance or Sponsor Management matter, please call us on +44 (0)20 3617 9173, email us at info@richmondchambers.com or complete our online enquiry form below.

WE CAN ALSO ASSIST WITH

Switching into the Skilled Worker Route



Visa Extensions for Skilled Workers



Changes of Employer or Role



Applications for Settlement as a Skilled Worker



Applications for British Citizenship Following Settlement



Refusals, Administrative Reviews and Judicial Reviews



Sponsor Licence Applications for Skilled Worker Sponsors



Ongoing Sponsor Licence Compliance



WHAT CAN WE HELP YOU WITH?

To discuss your Skilled Worker Visa application with one of our immigration barristers, contact our business immigration team on 0203 617 9173 or complete our enquiry form below.



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By Annie Ee – Senior Legal Associate
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By Georgina Griggs – Immigration Barrister
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RICHMOND CHAMBERS LLP

LONDON OFFICE

Richmond Chambers LLP
Seven Henrietta Street



Covent Garden

London

WC2E 8PS

T / +44 0203 617 9173

E / info@richmondchambers.com

MONTREUX OFFICE

Avenue Des Alpes 80B

Montreux 1820

Switzerland

T / +41 21 588 07 70

E / info@richmondchambers.ch

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